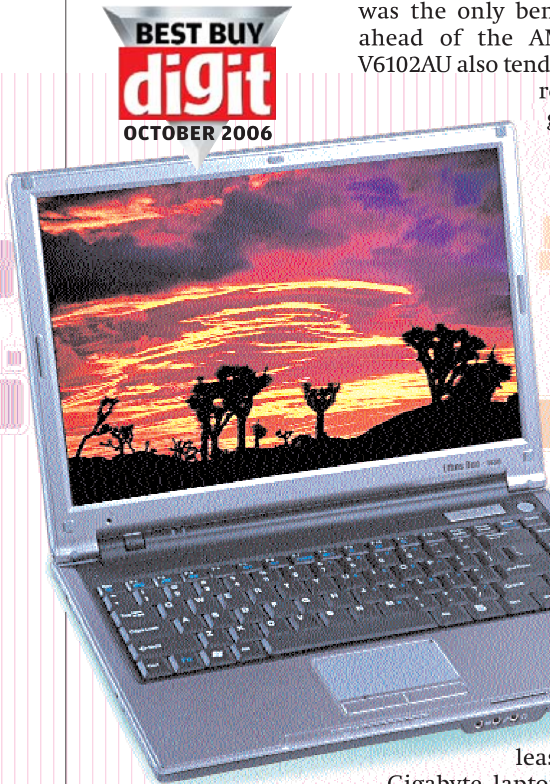

ACi finally redeems itself with the Ethos Duo 1430

was the only benchmark where Intel is way ahead of the AMD platform. The Compaq V6102AU also tends to get a little hotter than the rest of the laptops in the category; this might have something to do with the AMD platform.

The ACi Ethos Duo 1430 came in behind the Compaq V6102AU thanks to the Intel Core Duo processor, except for the battery test, where the Intel platform has a clear advantage over the Turion. ACi's Ethos 1530 was third, again thanks largely to the Intel Core Duo platform's power efficiency, which propels its performance score over the rest. Acer's Aspire 5551 came close to dislodging both the ACi laptops from the podium, had it come with at least 512 MB of memory. The Gigabyte laptops were based on the older Pentium M and Celeron M processors, and consequently, the scores were proportionally lower. However, we do expect them to introduce laptops with newer processors—for now, they are overshadowed by better products. The Zenith Strategist pulled a stunner by displaying some great battery life, but the performance in other tests was average at best.

Coming to battery life, the Compaq V6102AU posted the lowest—but two hours is not too shabby, considering the performance on offer. The Zenith Strategist was able to run our test for a full four hours, and with regular applications, it should go even further. Generally speaking, laptops based on the Pentium M and Core Duo processors were able to provide more battery life per charge.

Our Conclusion

There are many options to consider in the Entry-level category. First, if you are on an absolute shoestring budget, the cheapest you get is the ACi Emerald C2. From our past experience with ACi laptops, they weren't up to the mark—they generated too much heat. However, this time round, the Intel Centrino platform in the Emerald C2 is a tried-and-tested solution, and it's very hard to go wrong with it. Furthermore we didn't encounter any heating issues during the tests.

In the bracket nearing Rs 35,000, the Acer TravelMate 2428 is the best performer. There's nothing really wrong with the Gigabyte and Zenith laptops, but the Acer laptop's fit and finish, complemented by its superior performance, outclass Gigabyte and Zenith.

How We Tested

Here's a description of the tests and benchmarks we used to compare the laptops.

Features

Features such as the size of the display, the number of I/O ports, hard disk size, type of optical drive, etc. were noted and rated. Extra features, if present, were also noted. Weightages were assigned to the noted features according to their importance.

Usability

Usability is evaluated on the basis of how easy it is to handle the laptop in day-to-day life. Importance was given to weight and dimensions, as well as the ergonomics of the keypad, touchpad, etc. Music files were played to rate the speakers on a scale of 5.

Package Contents

We took into account the OS, recovery, and driver CDs provided by the vendor. Extra accessories or bundled software got extra points.

Performance

To gauge the performance, we ran a series of tests to evaluate each sub-system. We used the following benchmark suites:

PC Mark 2004 v1.3.0

This system-wide benchmark tests the entire system as well all the individual components—the CPU, memory, graphics sub-system, and hard drive. It returns the combined score as well as individual scores by running day-to-day apps such as file encryption, virus-scanning, and graphics applications.

SiSoft Sandra Engineer 2007

Another system-wide benchmark suite. We used it to evaluate the performance of the CPU, memory and hard disk.

Ziff-Davis Business Winstone 2004

This tests the system by performing a scripted run of applications used on a daily basis—MS Office, as well as applications such as Norton Anti-virus and WinZip. The overall system performance is evaluated, and a composite score is returned at the end of the run. The higher the score, the better is the system's performance.

Apart from these, we also did a few real-world tests:

Video encoding

This involved converting a 100 MB VOB file to AVI using DivX Creator 6.2, and the encoding time was noted.

Gaming benchmark

We tested the OpenGL capabilities with *Call of Duty*. The game was run at 800 x 600 and 1024 x 768 with all the details turned on. The average scores were noted.

LCD screen display tests

DisplayMate Video Edition was used to gauge the sharpness and level shift of the LCD screens.

Digit Battery Meter

We charged the battery to full capacity and then ran a VOB file until the battery ran out. During the test, the screensaver and power management features were disabled. The volume level was set to the maximum, brightness to 50 per cent, and Wi-Fi was turned off. This tells us whether the notebook will last a long enough to watch a full movie.